AN INVESTMENT THESIS · TRUSTMRR STARTUP UNIVERSE

Beyond the AI Gold Rush

Everyone is panning the same river. We went looking downstream.

A $10M fund. 1,000 revenue-generating startups. One question: **does the AI hype actually deserve the capital?**

197 AI STARTUPS SCREENED

339 INVESTABLE

9 FUNDED

Prepared for the Investment Committee · Session 3 Data Deep-Dive

THE SETUP

Great investors don't follow trends. They question them.

Every founder pitch this year opens the same way: “We're an AI company.” Every LP wants AI exposure. Every accelerator cohort skews AI. This dataset lets us test that instinct against real revenue instead of pitch decks.

THE QUESTION THIS DECK ANSWERS

If I had $10M to deploy into this pool, where would it actually go — and how much would land in AI?

01 THE HYPE
Size the AI wave by sheer count

02 THE MYTH
Test AI vs. the rest on hard revenue metrics

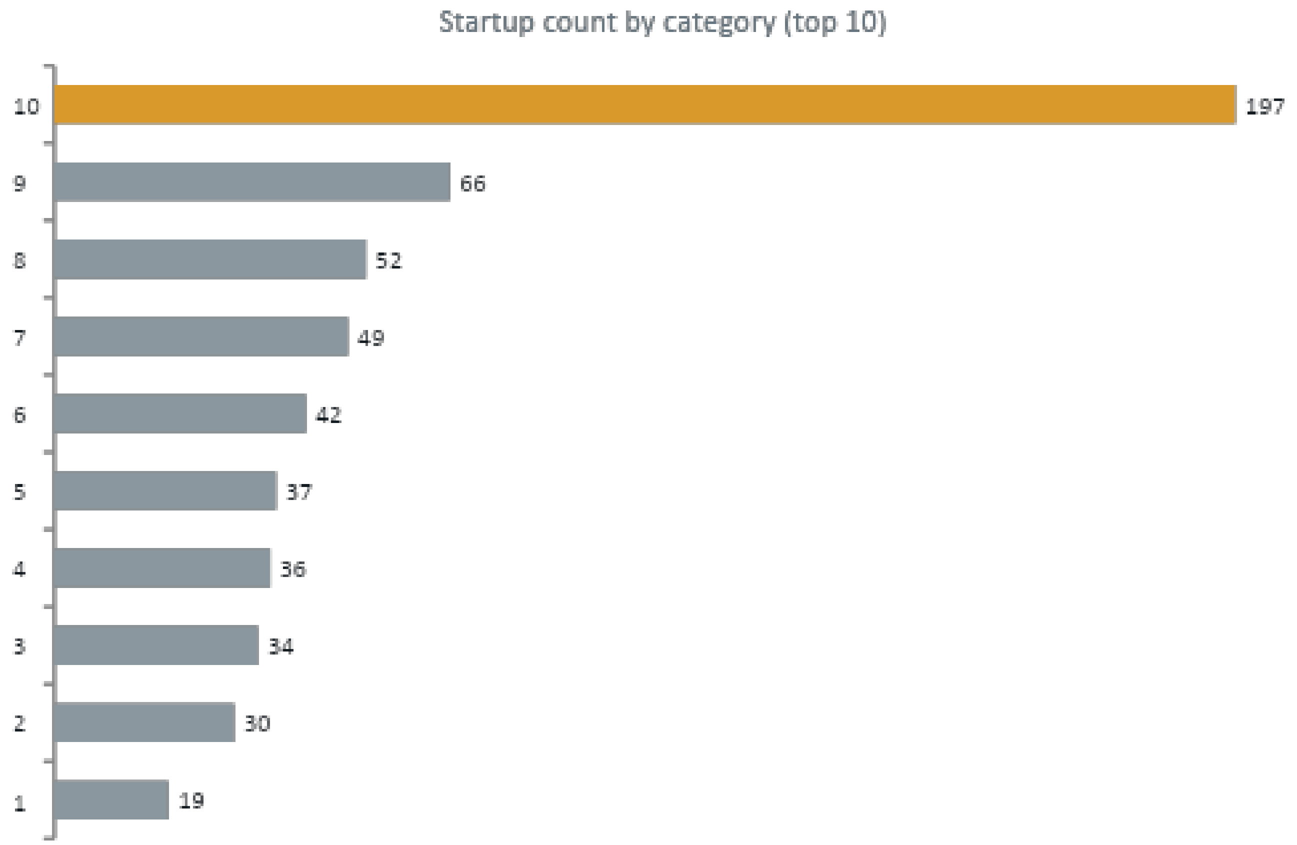
03 THE WINNERS
Score 339 investable startups on fundamentals

04 THE MAP
Sort winners into a 2×2 opportunity matrix

05 THE PORTFOLIO
Deploy the $10M, dollar by dollar

AI is the biggest category in the room — by far

Roughly one in five startups in the pool self-identify as AI. No other category is close. That is the attention the market is paying. The question is whether the revenue backs it up.



197

AI STARTUPS

out of 1,000 tracked

~2.9×

larger than the #2 category (SaaS, 66)

"If everyone is looking here, is anyone looking elsewhere?"

Does AI actually outperform? Not really.

Head-to-head on hard revenue metrics, AI startups edge out the rest of the market on size — but lag on the one metric a venture investor is actually buying: momentum.

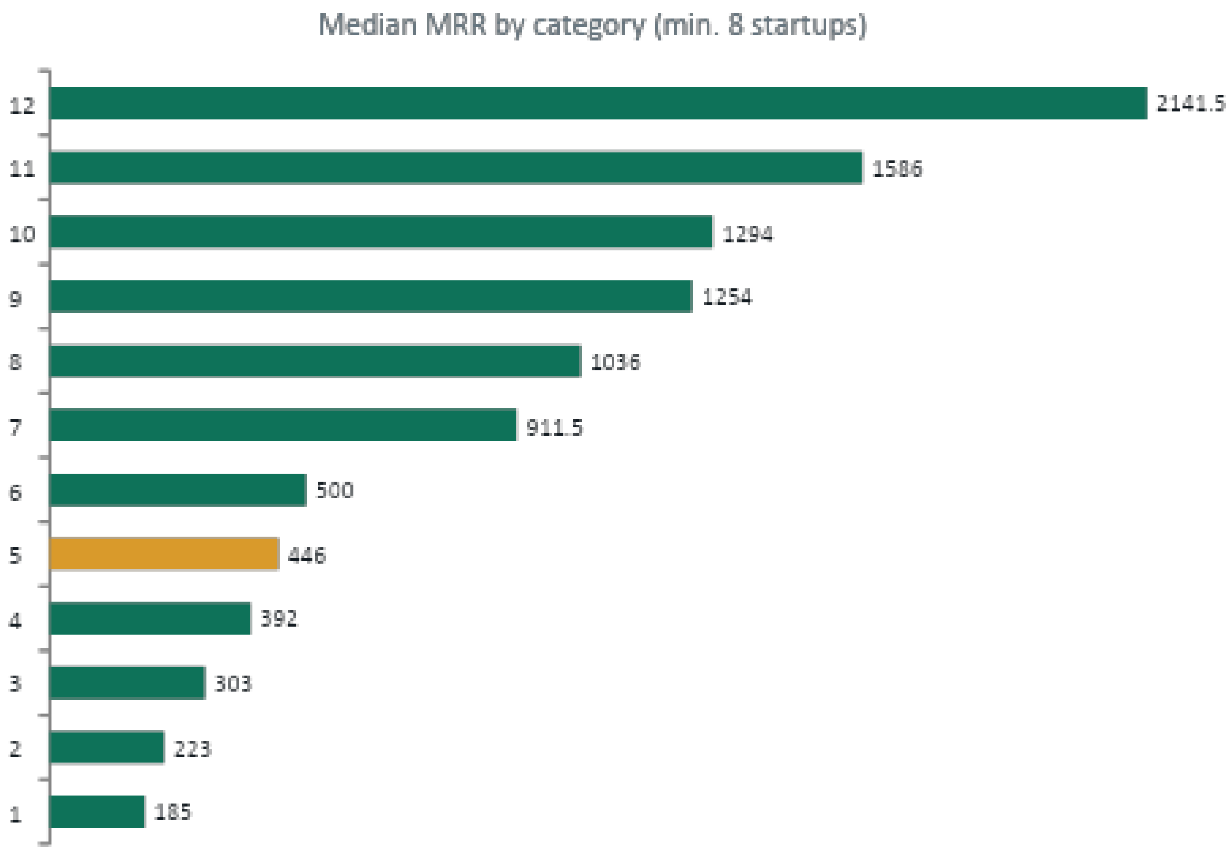
METRIC	AI STARTUPS	NON-AI STARTUPS	WHAT IT MEANS
Median MRR	$446	$277	AI ahead by 61% — real, but on a small base
Median lifetime revenue	$4,853	$3,659	AI ahead by 33% — partly just newer money
Median asking multiple	3.15×	2.30×	You pay ~37% more per revenue dollar
% of startups growing MRR	24.9%	31.8%	AI trails by 7 points — the headline finding
Median Domain Rating	12.5	13.0	Statistically tied — no brand advantage

Size without momentum is a warning sign, not a thesis. AI is bigger. It is not more alive.

Medians, labelled categories only (n = 197 AI, n = 529 non-AI). Fields: revenue_30d / 12m / all_time, mrr_growth_30d_pct, revenue_multiple, domain_rating.

AI ranks 8th out of 21 categories on median MRR

Every category with at least 8 startups, ranked by median monthly recurring revenue. Seven categories — none of them AI — out-earn the typical AI startup.



8th

of 21 categories, on the median startup's monthly revenue

4.8×

more MRR at the median Education startup than the median AI one

None of the seven categories above AI is a hyped one.

THE VERDICT ON ACT 2

AI has the crowd. It doesn't have the crown.

Being the largest category bought AI startups attention — and a richer asking price — but not superior revenue growth. The AI label is not, by itself, an investment signal.

So the question sharpens: which specific startups — AI or not — actually deserve capital?

Building a VC-style Investment Score

Revenue size alone rewards age, not quality. We scored the 339 startups with verifiable scale on four fundamentals, each converted to a percentile rank so no single metric can dominate.

40%

Revenue Scale

Current MRR — proof of real, paying demand today, not a story about tomorrow.

35%

Momentum

30-day MRR growth, winsorized so tiny-base spikes can't buy their way to the top.

25%

Traction Depth

Active subscriptions — breadth of the customer base, not one whale paying the bills.

+20%

Durability Bonus

Domain Rating — a proxy for a defensible SEO and brand moat. A bonus, not a core weight.

Investment Score = 0.8 × (0.40·MRR rank + 0.35·Growth rank + 0.25·Subscriber rank) + 0.2 × Domain Authority rank

Who gets scored: MRR ≥ $300 · 5+ paying subscribers · a real, named company (no "Stealth" listings) — 339 of 1,000 qualify.

Why percentile ranks: raw MRR and raw growth % live on wildly different scales. Ranking each metric first stops one $500K outlier from deciding the whole leaderboard.

The top 10 — and only three of them are AI

Ranked by Investment Score across the full 339-startup investable universe. Social tools, developer infrastructure and education crack the top 10 alongside AI.

#	STARTUP — WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES	CATEGORY	MRR	30-DAY	AI?
1	**Postiz** Open-source social scheduler — the self-hostable Buffer alternative, 32k+ GitHub stars.	Social Media	$177,102	+15.0%	—
2	**Supergrow** AI post writer and scheduler built exclusively for LinkedIn personal branding.	Social Media	$79,479	+24.9%	—
3	**GojiberryAI** Pre- and post-purchase survey app for Shopify stores — attribution and NPS.	AI	$494,668	+23.6%	AI
4	**LLM Gateway** Open-source unified API that routes requests across 40+ model providers.	AI	$47,172	+239.5%	AI
5	**Web3Forms** Serverless form backend — contact forms on static sites with zero server code.	Dev Tools	$33,002	+20.6%	—
6	**Kibu** Software for disability (IDD) providers — 600+ classes plus compliance records.	Education	$234,319	+52.8%	—
7	**Adspirer** AI agent that runs Google, Meta, TikTok and LinkedIn ad campaigns by chat.	Marketing	$54,684	+30.0%	—
8	**Codedex** Gamified learn-to-code platform — Duolingo-style XP and streaks for Python.	Education	$88,416	+1.4%	—
9	**Apiframe** Production API wrapper for Midjourney image generation — no Discord needed.	AI	$24,789	+31.0%	AI
10	**Liinks** Design-led link-in-bio page builder for creators.	Social Media	$30,890	+1.3%	—

Read the AI column. Only rows 3, 4 and 9 carry the label. The other seven are unglamorous tools with paying customers — and #7, Adspirer, is an AI ad agent the dataset files under “Marketing.” Labels are self-reported.

What the winners have in common

Across both AI and non-AI top performers, three mechanics repeat — and none of them is “has AI in the name.”

01

Real subscriber depth

Top-10 startups average 2,000+ active subscriptions. That breadth is what makes revenue durable — no single enterprise whale can leave and take the business with it. It is also the hardest number to fake.

Median top-10 subscriber base: 2,000+

02

An owned wedge, not a broad promise

Web3Forms owns “forms on static sites.” Simple Analytics owns “analytics without cookies.” Kibu owns “IDD disability providers.” GojiberryAI owns “Shopify post-purchase surveys.” Same mechanism, different markets.

The wedge is the moat — not the tech

03

Growth that compounds on a real base

LLM Gateway's +239% and Kibu's +53% sit on top of five- and six-figure MRR that already exists. Compare that to a startup going from $12 to $40 and posting +233%. Identical percentage, opposite meaning.

Momentum × scale, not momentum alone

Winning is a pattern, not a category. Every one of these three tests is category-blind — which is exactly why we can apply them to AI and non-AI companies alike.

Sorting the 339 into four kinds of bet

Horizontal: business performance (revenue + growth + traction). Vertical: market visibility (followers + domain authority).

THE BIG IDEA

Amber dots are scattered across all four quadrants, not clustered in the winning one.

Being AI doesn't place you anywhere in particular.

Representative startups from each quadrant, curated for readability (n = 339 scored). Positions are illustrative of rank, not to scale.

Hidden Gems: real revenue, no audience

The bottom-right quadrant is where price and performance are most dislocated. These companies are undervalued by the market's attention — not by their customers.

Dropkiller

E-COMM

$51K MRR · +38% growth · near-zero social following

A store-and-ad spy tool for dropshippers: point it at a Shopify store and it returns the theme, the installed apps, the product history and estimated sales.

Why it's a gem: it sells to an audience that buys tools quietly and never tweets about them. Low follower count here is a customer-behaviour artefact, not weak demand.

Upscale System

AI-TAGGED

$86.5K MRR · hiding behind a Domain Rating of just 14

A done-for-you B2B outbound growth operator — runs pilot campaigns across email, calling and LinkedIn, then scales whatever converts into a repeatable engine.

Why it's a gem: services-led revenue does not generate backlinks, so DR badly understates it. The market is reading a marketing metric as a business metric.

overrank SEO

MARKETING

smallest position in the fund · +91% growth

An SEO rank-tracking and page-optimisation tool. * Category label taken from the dataset; not independently verified.

Why it's a gem, cautiously: the growth is real but the base is small, so this is an optionality check — enough to earn information rights, not enough to hurt.

The arbitrage: visibility and performance are only loosely coupled. Every dollar of revenue the market hasn't noticed is a dollar you don't have to bid for.

The nine holdings

Five Future Unicorns form the core. Three Hidden Gems are the higher-conviction, lower-visibility bets. Every check has a thesis attached to it.

STARTUP — THE BUSINESS	CHECK	QUADRANT	WHY IT'S IN THE PORTFOLIO
GojiberryAI ● Shopify post-purchase survey and attribution app	$2.0M	Future Unicorn	Largest AI winner by revenue — the anchor position
Postiz Open-source, self-hostable social media scheduler	$1.8M	Future Unicorn	Proven scale, a real distribution moat, still growing
Kibu Compliance + content software for disability providers	$1.4M	Future Unicorn	+53% growth on a six-figure MRR base
Web3Forms Serverless form backend for static websites	$1.0M	Future Unicorn	DR 81 — the strongest moat in the portfolio
LLM Gateway ● Unified API routing across 40+ model providers	$0.9M	Future Unicorn	+239% growth; small check, asymmetric upside
Dropkiller Store and ad intelligence tool for dropshippers	$0.9M	Hidden Gem	$51K MRR and +38% with almost no visibility
Simple Analytics Cookieless, GDPR-compliant web analytics	$0.8M	Future Unicorn	Privacy positioning regulation keeps strengthening
Upscale System ● Done-for-you B2B outbound growth operator	$0.7M	Hidden Gem	$86.5K MRR hidden behind a DR of just 14
overrank SEO SEO rank tracking and page optimisation	$0.5M	Hidden Gem	Smallest check — optionality on +91% growth

● AI-labelled — 3 of 9 holdings, $3.6M of $10M. **Committed: $9.1M.** The remaining $0.9M is held as reserve / follow-on capital, not committed to a named startup this round.

WHAT THE DATA ACTUALLY PROVED

Five findings

01	**The AI label is not an investment signal.**	AI leads on size (+61% median MRR) and loses on momentum (24.9% of AI startups growing vs 31.8% of everyone else). Bigger, not more alive.
02	**And the market charges you a premium for it.**	3.15× vs 2.30× asking multiple. You are asked to pay roughly 37% more per dollar of revenue for the weaker growth profile.
03	**Category is a far worse predictor than fundamentals.**	AI ranks 8th of 21 categories on median MRR. The median Education startup earns 4.8× the median AI one. Seven unhyped categories out-earn it.
04	**Visibility and performance are only loosely coupled — and that gap is the opportunity.**	Dropkiller: $51K MRR, +38%, near-zero following. Sovereign Leads: DR 52, shrinking. Attention is priced. Performance isn't always.
05	**Winners share a mechanism, not a market.**	Subscriber depth, an owned wedge, and growth compounding on a base that already exists. All three tests are category-blind, which is why they work on AI and non-AI alike.

THE ASK

What I'm recommending we do

Five decisions for this committee — and the five things that would change my mind.

1 **Fund companies, not categories.**

Adopt the Investment Score (or an agreed equivalent) as a gate before any term sheet. No thematic allocations.

2 **Cap AI exposure at 35–40%, name by name.**

Our 36% is three companies that each cleared the bar alone — not a theme allocation, and never renewed as one.

3 **Overweight the Hidden Gems quadrant.**

21% across three names — where price and performance are most dislocated, and where our screen has the biggest edge.

4 **Screen out spikes on tiny bases, always.**

Winsorize growth before ranking. BillionVerify's +294% would otherwise have bought a place in this portfolio.

5 **Re-run the screen quarterly.**

A snapshot dated 30 Jul 2026, not a moat. Hold the uncommitted $0.9M for follow-ons into re-qualifying gems.

Decision requested today: approve the $9.1M committed, hold $0.9M in reserve.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE MY MIND

- Categories are self-reported. Adspirer is an AI ad agent filed under “Marketing” — the true AI count is likely above 197, which would soften the head-to-head gap.
- Multiples are asking prices, not transacted ones. Nobody has paid 3.15× yet.
- n = 339 after filters. Smaller categories carry real sampling noise.
- Domain Rating is an SEO proxy, not a moat. It systematically understates services-led businesses.
- 30-day growth is volatile at this revenue scale. One good month can move a rank.

THE TAKEAWAY

The biggest opportunity isn't investing in AI.

It's investing in the right AI companies — and knowing when not to.

1,000	339	9	64%
startups screened	cleared the bar	funded	outside AI